same as SP's and significantly higher than BSP's (see Figure 3.5). This radical shift in the social composition of its candidates reflects the critical importance of cultivating a new leadership in OBC communities for the BJP. SP was under no such compulsion due to its historical support base with these groups. The BJP, however, used its new caste-representation policy to attract many such groups to its side. These numbers reflect a radical shift in the BJP's attitude to caste: it wasn't just talking the talk. It was walking it in the form of tickets the parties distributed.

'I felt this sitting in the assembly in the last few years,' agreed one of the longest-serving independent MLAs in UP when I presented him with these findings. He was speaking off the record, but as a legislator who has continuously been a member of the state assembly since 1991, his response was telling. 'Come to the assembly in Lucknow and you will see the difference when you look at the origins of MLAs. There has been a big shift. We felt it beyond doubt and your numbers show what we have been feeling,' he said.[14]

The BJP's OBC turn in UP was predicated on a major social shift within the party's organisational structures in the state, starting from 2013. Amit Shah moved to Lucknow in early 2014 and took up residence on Rana Pratap Marg, near the *Times of India*'s (then) office in the city.[15] He was not BJP president at the time, but general secretary in charge of UP, and the party was led by Rajnath Singh, a Thakur leader and former UP chief minister himself. This was at a time when the BJP had not tasted significant electoral success in UP for over a decade. Shah's decision not to stay in a hotel and to take up a house signalled a new 'intent to the party's rank and file that the new leader wanted to stay here for the long haul.'[16] Shah had spent the years 2010–2012, when he was barred from entering Gujarat by the Supreme Court, living in Delhi but studying UP politics and travelling across the state. He says he learnt 'what was wrong with the BJP' during this time. The party had not fought panchayat elections in the state for twelve years, resulting in a whole 'army of politically conscious citizens', who, in his words, 'should have been with us joining other parties simply because we could not provide them with a political avenue'. Shah not only announced that the BJP